

Bill PDF Audit — How to Use This Report

A plain-English guide to reading bill_audit_report.xlsx

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Here's the short version: we took real electricity bills and checked each one against the list of things Texas requires to be on there. Every row in the "Results" tab is one bill. Every column is one required item — was it actually on the bill or not. This guide walks you through how to read what we found.

What the Four Colors Mean

Status	What It Means
PASS	We found this required item on the bill. Nothing to do here.
FAIL	We looked for this on the bill and couldn't find it. This is the one worth a real look — sometimes it's a genuine gap, and sometimes a brand just phrases things differently than we expected (both happen — see the real examples below).
REVIEW	We can't be fully certain from just reading the text. A person should glance at the actual bill for this one item. This is NOT the same as FAIL — it just means the automatic check has a genuine blind spot here.
SKIP	This check doesn't apply to this particular bill (for example, a rule that's only relevant to one utility territory, or a barcode that can't be checked by reading text).

How to Find the Real Problems Fast

1. Go to the "Results" tab.
2. Click the small filter arrow on any column header.
3. Uncheck everything except "FAIL" (or type FAIL into the filter search box).
4. That column now shows only the bills with a real problem for that specific item. Repeat for any other column you want to check.

For the fastest overview instead, go to the "Summary" tab first — it lists every check with how many bills passed, failed, needed review, or were skipped, sorted so the most common problems are at the top. Start there before diving into individual bills.

A Few Real Examples of What a FAIL Might Actually Mean

Not every FAIL is a mistake on the bill. While building this tool, we found real cases where a brand simply phrases something differently than we expected — for example, one brand writes "Acct #" where we were originally looking for "Account Number." We fix these as we find them, but it means a FAIL is a signal to go look at the real bill, not automatic proof something is wrong.

One specific case worth knowing: the "Customer Name / Billing Address" column will almost always show REVIEW, not PASS. That's because real bills print this information with no label at all — there's nothing for a text search to reliably confirm. This is an honest limitation, not a bug.

What This Report Does NOT Check

This only checks whether required information is PRESENT on the bill — not whether the numbers themselves are correct (for example, it confirms an "average price per kWh" message exists, but doesn't verify that number is calculated correctly). It also does not check the bill's visual layout — overlapping text, blank pages, or formatting problems are a separate, not-yet-built check.

What Each Check Actually Means

Every column in the "Results" tab and every row in the "Summary" tab is one of these 36 checks. Here's what each one is actually looking for on the bill, and why it's required.

Section 1 — Messages & Regulatory Notices

Solar Message: A required notice about residential solar energy options. Must appear on every residential bill, and must NOT appear on commercial bills.

Refer a Friend Message: A promotional message inviting the customer to refer friends. Required on residential bills, not commercial ones.

Power to Choose Message: A reference to powertochoose.com, the official Texas government website where customers can compare electricity providers. Required on residential bills.

Critical Care Message: A notice about protections for customers who depend on electrically powered medical equipment. Required only on April and October bills — must NOT appear in any other month.

Things You Should Know Notice: The required heading "THINGS YOU SHOULD KNOW ABOUT YOUR BILL," which explains how to report unauthorized charges and file a complaint.

Unauthorized Charges Notice: Confirms the bill explains what to do if the customer believes they were charged for something they didn't authorize.

PUCT Complaint Info: Confirms the required Public Utility Commission of Texas complaint-filing address and phone number are printed on the bill (P.O. Box 13326, Austin TX 78711, 936-7120).

TDU Emergency Contact: Confirms the bill lists the correct emergency/outage phone number for the company that actually delivers the electricity (e.g. Centerpoint, Oncor, AEP, TNMP — different from the company that bills the customer).

Section 2 — Customer Information

Account Number: The customer's account number, specific to their service with the company.

Service Address / ESI ID: The physical address where the electricity is actually delivered, and/or its ESI ID — a unique 17-digit number Texas uses to identify that exact service location.

Customer Name / Billing Address: The customer's name and the mailing address the bill is sent to. Almost always shows REVIEW rather than PASS or FAIL — see the note on this earlier in the guide.

Section 3 — Billing Summary

Bill Number: The unique number identifying this specific bill, different from the account number.

Bill Date: The date this bill was generated and issued.

Bill Period: The date range of electricity service this bill covers, e.g. March 23 to April 22.

Previous Balance: What the customer owed before this new bill was issued.

Current Charges: The new charges being billed for this specific period, before adding any previous balance.

Payments / Adjustments: Any payments received or credits/adjustments applied since the last bill.

Amount Due: The total amount the customer needs to pay, including any previous balance.

Due Date: The date payment is due.

Section 4 — Meter Information

Meter Reading Table: Confirms the table showing the meter number, reading dates, and usage is present on the bill.

Actual / Estimated Read: Confirms the bill states whether the meter reading used to calculate this bill was an actual reading or an estimate.

Usage (kWh): The amount of electricity the customer used this period, measured in kilowatt-hours.

Section 5 — Charges & Taxes

Energy Charges: The core charge for the actual electricity used, separate from delivery fees and taxes.

Base Charge: A flat fee charged every month regardless of how much electricity was used (sometimes called a customer charge). Not every brand itemizes this as its own line — see the real example earlier in this guide.

TDU Delivery Charges: Fees charged by the utility company that physically delivers the electricity over its power lines — separate from the company that bills the customer for the energy itself.

Gross Receipts Tax: A state tax on the electricity company's total sales, passed along to the customer as a line item on the bill.

PUC Assessment: A small fee that funds the state agency (the Public Utility Commission of Texas) that regulates electricity companies.

Market Securitization: A charge that helps pay back state-approved loans taken out to cover extreme costs from major events, like a winter storm. Not every brand lists this as its own line.

Total Current Charges: The sum of every charge for this billing period, added together into one total.

Section 6 — Agreement Details

Agreement Details Section: Confirms the section showing the customer's electricity plan and contract information is present on the bill.

Contract Dates: The start and end dates of the customer's current electricity plan.

Contract Expiration Notice: A message telling the customer when their current contract is valid until.

Average Price Message: A required message stating the average price per kilowatt-hour the customer paid this billing cycle. (This only checks that the message exists — not whether the number itself is calculated correctly.)

Variable Rate Message: A disclosure required specifically on variable-rate (non-fixed-price) electricity plans. Note: not yet verified against a real variable-rate bill — see the limitations section.

Section 8 — Usage History

Usage History Heading: Confirms the "Usage History" chart section — typically a bar graph of past usage — is present on the bill.

Usage History Month Labels: Confirms the usage chart has month labels, so the customer can actually read which month each bar represents.

Section 9 — Payment Coupon / Remittance Stub

Remittance Stub: The tear-off portion at the bottom of the bill that customers mail back in with a paper payment.

Stub Reference Number: The long number — often printed below a barcode — that payment processors use to route a mailed-in payment to the right account.

Barcode / QR Code: A scannable code used for payment processing. This tool cannot confirm whether a barcode image is actually present — it always shows SKIP for this one, since a barcode is a picture, not text.

Questions?

Contact Momna Ali. This tool and report are still being expanded — if something here looks wrong or confusing, that feedback directly helps make the next version better.